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Culture (OWC): [Chagga \(FN04\)](#)

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Place Coverage: Chagga, Tanzania

Section Title(S): 3. Marriage Taboos And Restrictions

If the young man asks the girl whether he may invite her to his mother's house for kena (milk porridge) or wari (beer) 83 and if the girl accepts the invitation, the two show the earnest desire to become engaged. On the appointed day the girl, accompanied by other girls of her age, appears in the home of the young man's mother, where, with some of his friends, he expects her. The young people eat and joke, and everybody treats the affair as an affair of the age group (rika). The parents of the young man have a chance to get acquainted with their son's beloved. There are a few more such invitations, though they are still not binding with regard to a betrothal. But the mutual inclination between the young people increases all the time while the families on both sides watch the romance with benevolence.

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Before members of their age group the young people exchange their salivas thereby establishing the alliance of their souls. The girl asks the man to spit the beer in his mouth into her mouth as a token of his earnest love and as a pledge that he would seek to obtain the consent of his sib. He takes a good sip of beer into his mouth, presses his lips upon her mouth into which he spurts the beer which she swallows. After this he requests that she do likewise as a token of her faithfulness. The onlookers watch the scene with benevolence and say: "How they love each other!" This love pledge is called iputsiana wari—to spit the beer into each other's mouth.

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The first beer invitation extended to the bride's father is not binding either. To avoid any obligation they give it the semblance of coincidence. In Moschi they call it "the beer of meeting on the way" (wari wokumbuhanana ndzien). They discuss the matter only in metaphors. The young man greets the bride's father by saying: "Ni ndasen owuka kokuidya ija koko ndeako. Indi wulalu ke kuidye na sia kunu kan koko mbe," i.e., "My father! You come from the soothsayer and you are just passing by my place. Master! Take the passage through my property with pleasure."—The young man's mkara, his best man, is the one who offers the beer, and he is also the speaker. The bride's father will not admit the purpose of his coming, he will rather say: "The rain has forced me to seek shelter with you. Let me stay here until 70 it is over. Then I shall go home, my son."

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*755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511*

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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